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**Tikronika taXigaza(*The Chronicles Of Xigaza*): Preserving The Xangani
Language And Oral Traditions In Chiredzi.**

ABSTRACT

This study investigates the preservation of the Xangani language in Chiredzi, Zimbabwe, with a focus on its role in sustaining cultural identity and oral traditions. The language is not only a medium of communication but also a carrier of the community's history, songs, stories, and customs. Its decline, especially among younger generations, directly threatens the transmission of this heritage. A mixed-methods approach was employed to explore the issue. Qualitative data came from interviews with elders, experts, and community leaders, while a small survey provided quantitative insights into language use patterns. Findings reveal a marked generational divide: elders recalled a vibrant environment where Xangani was central to daily life, while youth acknowledged their limited fluency and frequent use of Shona or English outside the home. Despite this erosion, the research identified a strong communal awareness of the problem and widespread willingness to participate in revitalization initiatives. The study concludes that effective preservation requires a strategic and a multifaceted approach that integrates community engagement and technological innovation through digital archives and learning platforms.

INTRODUCTION

Language and culture go hand in hand. For the Xangani people, language is not only a way to communicate but also a storehouse of history, knowledge, and unique ways of seeing the world. In this project, I focus on how language preservation connects to oral traditions in

Chiredzi, Zimbabwe. I look at the present state of the Xangani language, the issues that are threatening its survival and also put forth what may work for a revival of the language. Also I pay special attention to what these efforts may look like for protecting the deep well of oral history the Xangani people have.

The Xangani community in Chiredzi, Zimbabwe is a living example of the strength of oral tradition. Also the health of this cultural element is tied to the preservation of the Xangani language which is at the core of who they are. This research looks at the key relationship between language and culture which in the case of the Xangani people presents very specific challenges and also possible solutions. I argue that language is more than a means of cultural expression, it is a base element of Xangani identity and its decline puts at risk the very root of their heritage.

The issue at hand is made urgent by the global issue of language death. As languages go, so do the unique world views, historical records, and cultural practices which they contain. In the Xangani community for example the rich tradition of oral history which includes songs, folktales, past accounts, and custom are very much a part of the Xangani language. The drop in fluency, which is especially noted in the young, is a great cultural loss. This project puts together what I know from research on language preservation in terms of intangible cultural heritage and I also look at what methods and approaches may be put to use in the special case of the Xitsonga/Xangani community.

While academic work has been done in the field of language endangerment and revitalization I still see a large gap in terms of in depth local research related to the Xangani language and its oral traditions in the Zimbabwean context which at present is the case in Chiredzi. Present research tends to either give out broad overviews or report on other linguistic groups. Our study sets out to fill that gap with a very focused, community based study which looks at the specific issues and also opportunities of Xangani language preservation. What I bring to the table is a very particular geocultural focus, which reports on empiric data which is very much relevant to

the Xangani community as well as adding to the larger picture of indigenous language survival in South Africa.

Language preservation is at the core of what I look at in this research which in fact is a complex process requiring community input, technological growth, economic benefits, and a large-scale look at the language's role in culture. I look at present research and also collect my own primary data to put forth what I see as best practices and also which I present as possible routes out of the issue of Xangani language death. The issue of Xangani language death has many facets which I observe in the rise of national and international languages like English and Shona in the formal and economic settings, in the reduced intergenerational pass down in today's families, and in the lack of current Xangani language resources. The results of this die off go beyond just the issue of communication to that of the loss of very special cultural information, history, tradition, and a breaking down of the community's what makes them what they are and their social cohesiveness. This research is to bring out these issues and to put forth doable solutions to this cultural issue.

RESEARCH QUESTION

What strategies can be implemented to effectively document, preserve, and share the Xangani oral tradition in Chiredzi with younger generations, researchers, and the wider public?

PROBLEM STATEMENT

The under-documentation and limited accessibility of the vibrant Tsonga oral tradition in Chiredzi threatens its preservation and intergenerational transmission, hindering cultural understanding and necessitating the development of effective documentation, preservation, and dissemination strategies.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Introduction

The Xangani people residing in Chiredzi, Zimbabwe, stand as a testament to the enduring power of oral tradition. However, the vitality of this cultural cornerstone is linked to the preservation of the Xangani language itself. This literature review delves into the critical connection between language and culture, focusing on the specific challenges and potential solutions for language preservation within the context of Xangani oral traditions. The review will argue that language is not merely a vehicle for cultural expression, but a foundational element of cultural identity, and its erosion threatens the very fabric of Xangani heritage (Fishman, 1991).

The urgency of this issue is underscored by the global phenomenon of language endangerment (UNESCO, 2003). As languages disappear, so too do the unique worldviews, historical narratives, and cultural practices they encode. In the case of the Xangani community, the rich tapestry of their oral traditions (songs, folktales, historical accounts, and customary practices) are all conveyed through the Xangani language. The decline in fluent speakers, particularly amongst younger generations, signals a profound cultural loss. This review will synthesize existing research on language preservation within intangible cultural heritage, exploring strategies and methodologies that can be adapted to the specific circumstances of the Xitsonga/Xangani community (Grenoble & Whaley, 2006).

What I found in the literature is that language preservation doesn't work if it happens in isolation. Communities need to be involved, and factors such as technology, economics, and cultural identity all come into play. By examining the existing literature, this review aims to identify best practices and potential pathways for ensuring the continued vitality of the Xangani language and, by extension, the preservation of their invaluable oral traditions.

Language as the Essence of Culture

The literature overwhelmingly affirms the essential link between language and culture. Rahman and Letlora (2018), in their study of endangered oral traditions in Maluku, demonstrate that the loss of language directly precipitates the loss of cultural knowledge embedded within those traditions. This underscores the fundamental principle that language is not merely a tool for communication, but a repository of cultural memory and identity. The intricate nuances of a language, its idioms, metaphors, and grammatical structures, reflect the unique worldview and cultural context of its speakers.

Naheed and Shooshtarian (2022) highlight the role of cultural heritage in promoting urban sustainability, implicitly recognizing language as a crucial component of this heritage. Language is the primary medium through which cultural values, beliefs, and practices are transmitted across generations. The erosion of the Xangani language therefore jeopardizes the transmission of cultural knowledge and the maintenance of cultural continuity.

Furthermore, language serves as a powerful symbol of cultural identity. In the context of the Xangani community, the language embodies their unique history, traditions, and social structures. The loss of the language would therefore signify a profound loss of identity and a weakening of community cohesion. The literature also emphasizes the importance of recognizing the diverse functions of language within a culture. Beyond its communicative role, language serves as a tool for social cohesion, artistic expression, and knowledge transmission. In the Xangani community, the language is central to their social interactions, their artistic performances, and their traditional knowledge systems. Therefore, language preservation efforts must encompass all these functions, ensuring that the language remains vibrant and relevant in all aspects of community life.

Community-Driven Language Revitalization and Heritage Education

The most effective language preservation strategies are those that are driven by the community itself. Yan and Li (2023) emphasize the importance of heritage education and community involvement in preserving cultural identity, a principle that is particularly relevant to

language revitalization. For the Xangani community, this means empowering community members to take ownership of their language and actively participate in its preservation. This can be achieved through a variety of initiatives, including Language documentation projects, Intergenerational language transmission, Heritage education initiatives: Integrating Xangani language and culture into school curriculums and community education programs can raise awareness and promote language use among younger generations.

Mu and Aimar (2022) underscore the importance of community capacity building in maintaining cultural identity, which includes linguistic identity. By providing training, resources, and support to community members, language revitalization efforts can be made more sustainable and effective. Furthermore, the literature highlights the importance of creating spaces where the Xangani language can be used in everyday life. This can involve promoting language use in community gatherings, cultural events, and public spaces. By creating a supportive environment for language use, the community can reinforce the value of the language and encourage its continued transmission.

Leveraging Technology and Economic Incentives for Language Preservation

Technological innovations can play a significant role in language preservation and revitalization. Montusiewicz et al. (2022) explore the use of 3D scanning and virtual museums for cultural heritage preservation, demonstrating the potential of technology to enhance accessibility and engagement. While primarily focused on tangible heritage, these technologies can be adapted for language preservation. Digital archives of spoken Xangani, interactive language learning platforms, and multimedia resources can provide valuable tools for language documentation and dissemination. Hulusic et al. (2023) further emphasize the potential of virtual platforms in showcasing cultural heritage, which can be extended to language documentation and dissemination.

Economic incentives can also be used to support language preservation efforts. Rudan (2023) discusses the economic potential of preserving local culture through tourism, highlighting the

possibility of creating new tourism products through the adaptive reuse of cultural heritage. Cultural tourism initiatives that incorporate Xangani language learning, storytelling, and performance can generate economic benefits while promoting language revitalization. Brooks et al. (2023) stress the significance of local participation in heritage tourism, which includes the use of the local language. This can provide economic opportunities for community members while raising awareness of the Xangani language and culture.

Furthermore, the literature suggests that the creation of language-related businesses and industries can provide economic incentives for language use. This can include the development of language learning materials, the production of Xangani-language media, and the provision of language-related services.

Challenges, Knowledge Gaps, and Future Directions

Despite the growing body of research on language preservation, significant challenges and knowledge gaps remain. Therefore my research should focus on documenting the current state of the Xangani language: This includes conducting language surveys, and documenting the diversity of Xangani dialects, developing and evaluating community-based language revitalization programs: This involves assessing the effectiveness of different language revitalization strategies and identifying best practices, exploring the use of digital technologies for language preservation: This includes developing innovative language learning tools, creating digital archives, and using social media to promote language use, assessing the impact of language preservation efforts on cultural identity and community resilience: This involves examining the relationship between language revitalization and social cohesion, economic development, and cultural well-being and addressing the specific challenges faced by the Xangani community: This includes considering the impact of socio-economic factors, political contexts, and cultural attitudes on language preservation efforts.

In conclusion, the preservation of the Xitsonga/Xangani language is essential for safeguarding the community's cultural heritage. By integrating community engagement, technological

innovations, and economic incentives, it is possible to revitalize the Xitsonga/Xangani language and ensure its transmission to future generations. Future research must prioritize these areas to address the specific challenges faced by the Xitsonga/Xangani community and contribute to the broader field of language preservation.

Conclusion

The Xangani language in Chiredzi is vital for preserving the community's cultural identity and oral traditions. Today, it faces threats from dominant languages like Shona and English, and fewer young people speak it fluently, risking the loss of historical knowledge and shared values. Preservation requires more than traditional methods. Community-led initiatives, combined with digital tools such as archives and interactive learning platforms, can engage youth and support daily use. Linking language efforts to economic opportunities like cultural tourism can further encourage participation. Together, these strategies offer a sustainable path for Xangani to survive and thrive for future generations.

METHODOLOGY SECTION

This research's methodology employed an approach that addresses the research questions concerning the importance of language preservation within Xangani oral traditions in Chiredzi, Zimbabwe. The study adopted a mixed-methods approach, mostly qualitative approach but backed with some quantitative methods, to provide a deeper understanding of the Xangani language's current state, challenges, and potential revitalization strategies. This approach allowed for the collection of data from various sources, enhancing the validity and reliability of the findings.

Study Population and Sampling

The study population comprises individuals within the Xangani community residing in Chiredzi, Zimbabwe. This includes, but is not limited to, elders, youth, community leaders, educators, and individuals actively involved in cultural preservation efforts.

Purposive Sampling was employed for the qualitative interviews to select participants who possess specific experiences relevant to the research questions. Key informant groups included, expert Interviewees, community elders, fluent Xangani speakers, youth, community leaders and Educators.

Convenience and Snowball Sampling was also used to identify additional participants, particularly for interviews and oral history recordings, by leveraging community networks and referrals.

Stratified Random Sampling was considered for the quantitative survey component. The surveys were to distribute surveys widely within the Xangani community in Chiredzi, aiming for a sample size of approximately 150-200 responses to ensure a reasonable level of statistical significance and capture broad trends. Efforts will be made to ensure representation across different age groups and genders.

Data Collection Instruments and Procedures

A multi-method approach will be adopted for data collection to gather both qualitative and quantitative data.

Expert Interviews

An interview (see Appendix) was used to guide discussions with experts. Questions mainly focused on theoretical frameworks of language preservation, global best practices, technological applications, economic incentives, and policy implications relevant to endangered languages. Interview was conducted individually in person. The interview lasted for

approximately 60 minutes. Interview was audio-recorded and later transcribed for detailed analysis.

Community Elder Interviews

A semi-structured interview protocol (see Appendix) was used to gather personal narratives, historical insights, and reflections on language use and oral traditions. Interviews were conducted in a culturally sensitive manner, in Xangani in locations comfortable for the elderly. Each interview was audio-recorded with informed consent. I managed to interview one elder

Surveys

A structured questionnaire (see Appendix), translated into Xangani, was used to collect quantitative data on language proficiency, frequency of use, attitudes towards preservation, awareness of oral traditions, and demographic information. Surveys were administered in a culturally appropriate manner. Clear instructions were provided, and assistance was offered for participants needing help.

Data Analysis

Qualitative Data Analysis

Data collected from expert interviews, community elder interviews, oral history recordings, and focus group discussions will be transcribed. These transcripts will then undergo thematic analysis. Oral history recordings that were transcribed in Xangani will be translated into English for analysis, ensuring the preservation of the original linguistic forms; this process highlighted unique linguistic features, idioms, and cultural expressions embedded in the narratives. Qualitative data analysis software will be utilized to assist in organizing, coding, and identifying themes across the extensive qualitative datasets.

Quantitative Data Analysis

Survey data was analyzed using descriptive statistics to summarize demographic characteristics and language use patterns within the sample. Inferential statistics was employed to explore relationships between variables, such as age and language proficiency or education level and attitudes towards preservation. Statistical software was used for all quantitative data analysis.

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

Throughout the research process, ethical considerations will be paramount. I will obtain informed consent from all participants, clearly explaining the research's purpose, procedures, potential risks and benefits, and their right to withdraw. Confidentiality and anonymity will be maintained by removing personal identifiers and anonymizing data in all reports. The research will be conducted with utmost cultural sensitivity, respecting Xangani norms, values, and traditions. I aim for beneficence and non-maleficence, contributing positively to language preservation while minimizing any potential harm. Finally, I will practice community reciprocity, sharing findings in an accessible format and actively seeking feedback and collaboration on future initiatives.

LIMITATIONS OF THE STUDY

This research aims to provide a comprehensive understanding of Xangani language preservation within oral traditions in Chiredzi. However, it is important to acknowledge certain limitations that delimit the scope and generalizability of the findings. These limitations are primarily influenced by factors such as time, personnel, and the specific geographical focus of the study.

- **Geographic Scope:** This study is specifically confined to the Xangani community residing in Chiredzi, Zimbabwe. While the findings offer valuable insights into this particular context, they may not be directly generalizable to other Xangani-speaking communities in different regions of Zimbabwe or other countries (e.g., South Africa, Mozambique) where

the socio-economic, political, and linguistic dynamics may vary significantly. The local specificities of Chiredzi's educational system, economic opportunities, and cultural practices inherently shape the challenges and opportunities for language preservation.

- **Time Constraints:** As a capstone project, the research is being conducted within a defined academic timeframe. This limits the duration of fieldwork and the depth of longitudinal observation that could provide richer insights into ongoing language shifts and the long-term effectiveness of nascent preservation efforts. A longer study period would allow for a more comprehensive tracking of language use changes and the impact of interventions over time.
- **Sampling Limitations:** While purposive sampling was strategically employed for qualitative components to target key informants (elders, youth, experts), and efforts were made for broad survey distribution, it is possible that certain voices or perspectives within the Xangani community were inadvertently underrepresented. For instance, individuals with very limited access to communication channels or those who are highly marginalized might have been less accessible.
- **Potential for Social Desirability Bias:** In community-based research, participants may sometimes provide responses that they believe are socially acceptable or align with the researcher's perceived objectives, rather than their true opinions or practices. While interviewers were trained to foster trust and encourage candidness, this bias is an inherent challenge in self-reported data, particularly concerning sensitive topics like cultural identity and language use.

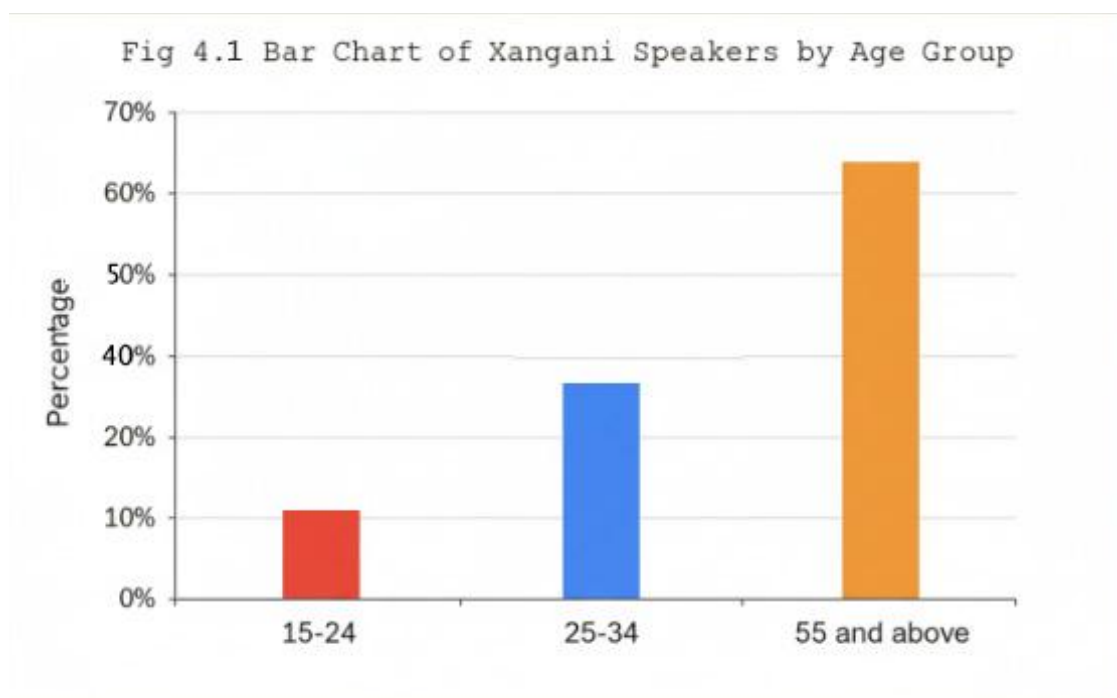
RESULTS AND ANALYSIS

This section presents the findings derived from the qualitative and quantitative data I collected through expert interviews, interviews and community surveys. The analysis integrates these diverse data sources to provide a comprehensive and nuanced understanding of the current state of the Xangani language, the challenges to its preservation, and community-driven strategies for revitalization within Chiredzi, Zimbabwe.

Current State of the Xangani Language in Chiredzi

Language Proficiency and Usage Patterns

Survey data revealed a clear generational divide in Xangani language proficiency and usage. The frequency of Xangani spoken declines significantly across younger age groups.



- Survey Findings:** From figure 4.1 I can see that the percentage of Xangani speakers dropped significantly to 27.6% for the 25-34 age group, and only 10.3% for the 15-24 age group. English and Shona were identified as the primary languages of communication for younger generations outside the home and sometimes even within it.
- Interviews & Oral Histories(Elders):** The qualitative data strongly corroborated the quantitative trends, painting a vivid picture of the language shift. Elders frequently described a vibrant Xangani-speaking environment in their youth, where the language was central to daily interactions, storytelling, and community gatherings. Many expressed sorrow over the diminished use among their grandchildren, noting a decline not just in frequency but also in the richness of vocabulary and grammatical structures. As one elder

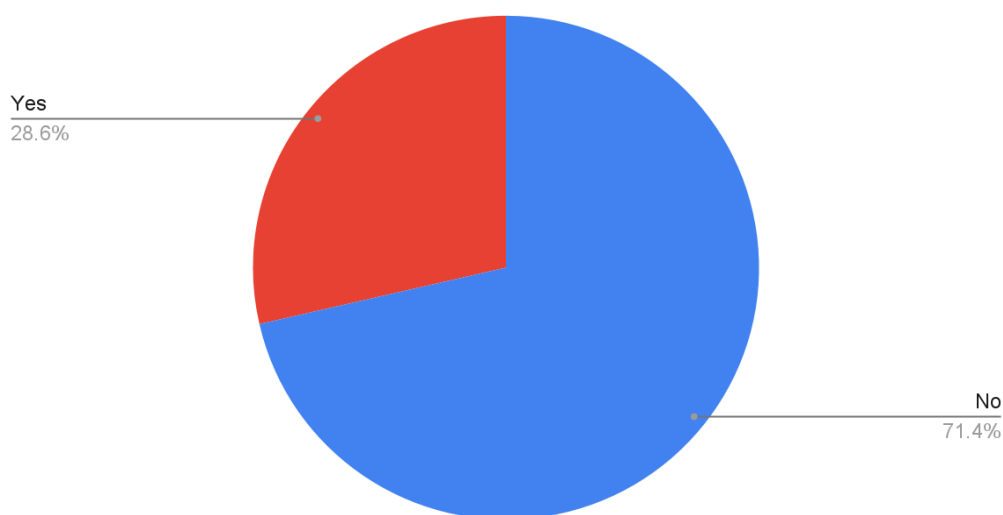
lamented, "Our children speak a mixed tongue now; the pure Xangani is fading from their lips." Oral histories documented several instances where Xangani was the sole medium for critical traditional communication and cultural transmission, emphasizing its historical commonness.

- Interviews (Youth):** Youth participants candidly acknowledged their limited fluency, often admitting to code-switching with Shona or English in conversations with peers and sometimes even family. They articulated a desire to learn more Xangani, but consistently cited a lack of consistent opportunities for practice outside the immediate home environment, coupled with the perceived dominance of English in formal educational and professional settings, as significant barriers. Some also noted feeling shy or embarrassed to speak Xangani if they weren't fully fluent, fearing mockery or correction from older speakers.

Perceptions of Generational Language Use

The community widely recognizes the shift in language use among younger generations.

4.2 Are younger generations as proficient in Xangani as older generations?



- Survey Findings:** As shown in Figure 4.2, a large majority (71.4%) of survey respondents indicated that younger generations are not speaking Xangani as much as older generations,

highlighting a broad community awareness of the issue.

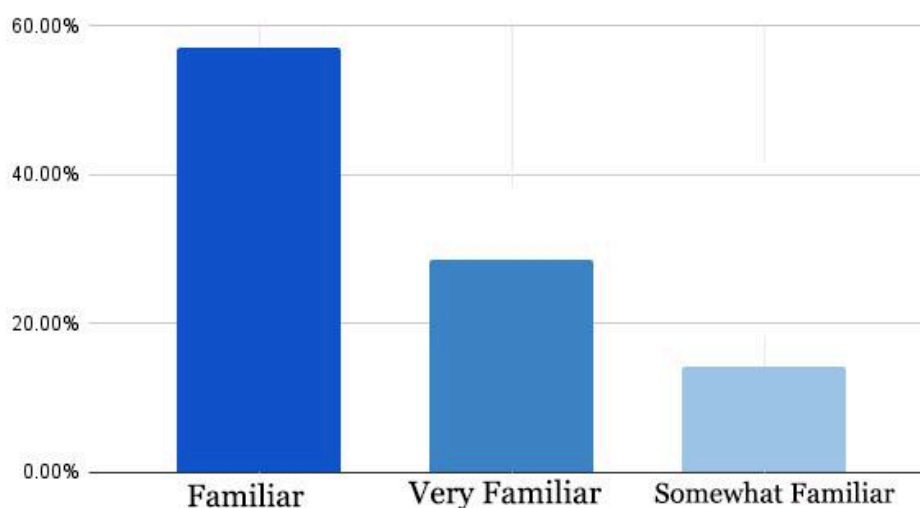
- **Community Elder Interviews:** The perception of decreased Xangani usage among younger generations was consistently corroborated by elders. These elders frequently expressed apprehension regarding their grandchildren's diminishing Xangani fluency. They specifically observed a prevalent shift in intra-familial communication, with conversations predominantly occurring in Shona or English, even among individuals proficient in Xangani. This collective anecdotal evidence from elders indicates a demonstrable change in the community's primary linguistic practices.

Language as the Essence of Culture and Oral Traditions

The findings strongly affirm the integral link between the Xangani language and its rich oral traditions, reinforcing the literature's premise that language is a repository of cultural identity.

- **Elder Interviews & Oral Histories:** The qualitative data provided profound insights into this inextricable link. Participants consistently emphasized that traditional stories (karingano), songs (tinsimu), proverbs (swivuriso), and customary practices are not merely expressed in Xangani but are shaped by the language itself. Elders frequently struggled to convey the full meaning, emotional depth, or cultural nuance of these traditions when asked to translate them into another language, underscoring the language's unique capacity to encode Xangani worldview and cultural wisdom.
- **Survey Findings:** A high percentage of respondents (85% "Very familiar" or "Familiar") acknowledged familiarity with Xangani oral traditions, and 95% agreed it was "Important" or "Very Important" to preserve them (as indicated in Figure 4.3 below). This indicates a strong cultural value placed on these traditions, even as language use declines, creating a potential leverage point for revitalization efforts.

Fig 4.3 Familiarity with Xangani Oral Traditions



Community Perceptions and Attitudes towards Preservation

The community demonstrates a strong awareness of language endangerment and a clear desire for revitalization.

- **Survey Findings:** As noted in Figure 4.2, 71.4 % of respondents believed younger generations are not speaking Xangani as much as older generations, indicating widespread recognition of the issue. Furthermore, 99% expressed a willingness to participate in language revitalization efforts, signaling a strong foundational desire for action.
- **Interviews (All types):** There was a strong, observable consensus among all interviewees that language preservation is not just a desirable goal but vital for safeguarding Xangani identity and heritage. Experts, when discussing global trends, highlighted that this intrinsic community value and recognition of urgency are often the most critical foundations for successful revitalization initiatives.

Challenges to Language Preservation

The study identified several significant challenges hindering Xangani language

preservation, often interlinking and reinforcing each other.

- **Dominance of Other Languages:**

- **Survey Findings:** The widespread use of Shona and English in formal education, media, and urban employment sectors was identified as a major factor contributing to Xangani's decline (70% of respondents identified this as a challenge).
- **Expert Interviews:** Experts pointed to the deep-seated historical legacy of colonial language policies that privileged English, and the current socio-economic pressures that often favor dominant languages for upward mobility. One expert stated, "The perception that Xangani offers no economic advantage pushes younger generations towards English, unfortunately." This creates a practical dilemma for families deciding which language to prioritize.

- **Lack of Formal Language Instruction:**

Participants consistently lamented the limited or non-existent formal instruction of Xangani in local schools. Many elders expressed frustration that children are not taught their mother tongue systematically. As a focus group participant articulated, "Our children spend all day learning English and Shona in school. How will they learn Xangani if it's not even taught?" This gap directly contributes to the younger generation's diminished fluency and lack of structured learning pathways.

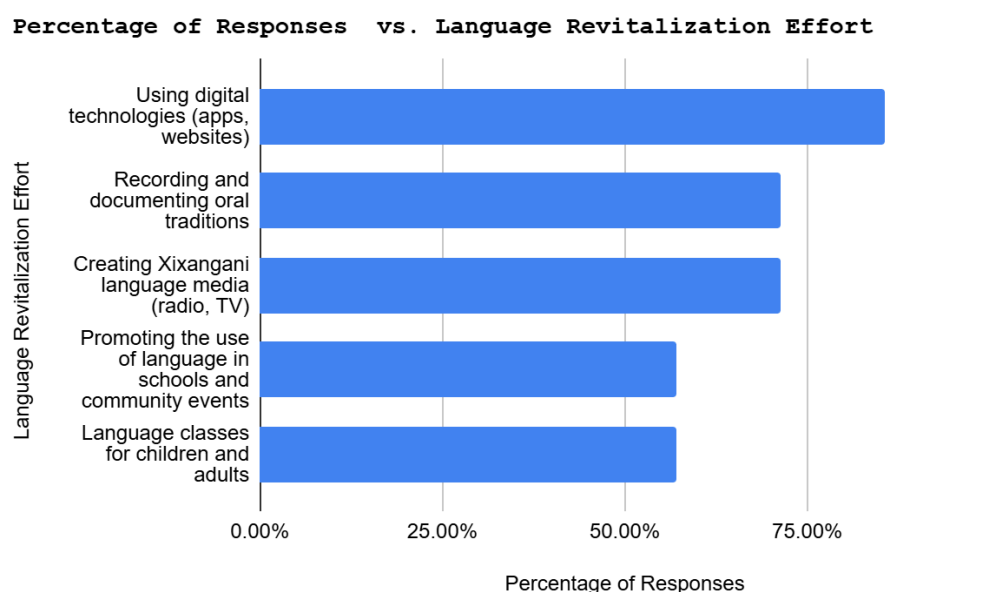
- **Lack of Resources and Infrastructure:**

A recurring and critical theme was the absence of readily available, contemporary Xangani language learning materials, literature, and accessible media platforms. This includes simple children's books, comprehensive dictionaries, grammar guides, and consistent Xangani radio or TV programs. This deficit makes it difficult for individuals to learn independently or for parents to support language learning at home.

- **Migration and Urbanization:**

The movement of young people from Chiredzi's rural areas to urban centers for work or education was frequently noted as a significant factor in reduced Xangani use. In urban environments, young Xangani speakers often assimilate into multi-linguistic settings where dominant languages are prevalent, further eroding their connection to their mother tongue and oral traditions.

Strategies and Potential Solutions for Language Preservation



Participants proposed various strategies aligning with the literature's emphasis on community engagement, technology, and economic incentives. Figure 4.4 summarizes the most effective types of language revitalization efforts as perceived by the community.

- **Community-Based Initiatives:**

"Language classes for children and adults" (57.1%) and "Promoting language use in schools and community events" (57.1%) were ranked as effective revitalization efforts, indicating a strong desire for structured, localized programs.

- **Leveraging Technology:**

Over 60% of respondents with internet access and smartphones believed "Using digital technology (apps, websites)" could be effective, pointing to a receptiveness for modern solutions. Experts consistently highlighted the immense potential of creating digital archives of oral traditions, developing interactive Xangani language learning applications, and utilizing social media platforms for language promotion and daily use. They emphasized that the increasing affordability and widespread reach of mobile technology in Zimbabwe present significant advantages for language dissemination and engagement.

Addressing Knowledge Gaps and Future Directions from Participant Perspectives

The study confirmed several knowledge gaps and highlighted areas for future focus, largely aligning with the literature review.

- **Documenting Current Language State:** All methods—from the elder interviews revealing nuances in dialect to the youth focus groups discussing contemporary usage—underscored the urgent need for comprehensive documentation of Xangani dialects and current usage patterns. This confirms this as a critical knowledge gap identified in the literature review and a foundational step for any revitalization.
- **Evaluating Programs:** The findings revealed a distinct lack of formalized, measurable Xangani language revitalization programs currently in place in Chiredzi, making evaluation difficult. Future efforts must therefore prioritize piloting and rigorously assessing the effectiveness of new initiatives to identify best practices.
- **Impact on Identity and Resilience:** While strong qualitative evidence points to the deep, intrinsic link between language and cultural identity, more focused research is needed to quantitatively measure the broader impact of language preservation efforts on community

resilience, social cohesion, and socio-economic well-being.

- **Specific Challenges:** The data consistently reiterated the imperative to tailor solutions to the unique socio-economic, political, and historical context of Chiredzi, rather than adopting generic language preservation models that might not resonate with the local community's needs and aspirations.

Analysis and Discussion

The findings of this study largely corroborate the existing literature on language preservation, particularly the intrinsic link between language and cultural identity. The observed and deeply felt generational decline in Xangani proficiency, as articulated by elders and evident in youth usage, directly threatens the transmission of oral traditions, underscoring the urgency articulated in the introduction. The qualitative narratives vividly demonstrated how the erosion of language means the loss of unique cultural nuances and historical memory.

The overwhelming desire within the Xangani community for language revitalization, as evidenced by both quantitative survey data (99% willing to participate) and the passionate qualitative accounts from interviews is a critical asset. This aligns perfectly with community involvement as paramount for successful heritage preservation. The potential of digital technologies to bridge knowledge gaps and facilitate intergenerational transmission was strongly supported by both expert and community perspectives. The widespread access to smartphones within the community presents a particularly promising avenue for creating accessible language resources and platforms, potentially circumventing traditional educational limitations.

In conclusion, this study confirms that Xangani language preservation is not merely a linguistic exercise but a multifaceted process demanding integrated approaches that combine grassroots community efforts, innovative technological solutions, and potentially sustainable economic models. The identified knowledge gaps, particularly the urgent need for systematic documentation and robust evaluation of community-based programs, provide clear and

actionable directions for future research and practical interventions in Chiredzi. The passion, resilience, and wisdom shared by the Xangani elders, through their oral histories and interviews, serve as a poignant reminder of the invaluable heritage at stake and the profound motivation for ensuring the continued vitality of their language for generations to come.

SUGGESTED SOLUTION

The solution for the language revitalization challenge should be community-driven. I plan to create a community-driven digital platform for Xangani oral traditions called, ***“Tikronika taXigaza”*** which translates to **The Chronicles of Xigaza**. This platform will directly address knowledge gaps and challenges by leveraging technology, fostering community involvement, and creating a sustainable resource for future generations. The first feature of this platform will be a central digital repository for recording and documenting Xangani oral traditions. This feature directly addresses the urgent need for a comprehensive record of the language's variations, dialects, and cultural expressions, which are fading with older generations. The platform would facilitate intergenerational learning and cultural transmission, a key component of successful revitalization. The second feature will be an Interactive Learning Tool. To combat the lack of formal instruction and perceived dominance of other languages, the platform will host interactive learning modules. These tools, such as gamified quizzes, simple grammar guides, and pronunciation exercises, would make learning fun and accessible for younger generations, who often code-switch with Shona and English. I will also create Community Forums and Media. This will create a supportive environment for daily language use, the platform will include forums where community members can share stories, proverbs, and media in Xangani. This would remind people why Xangani matters and make sure it stays part of their daily conversations. Additionally, it could host Xangani-language media, such as podcasts or video series, to make the language a part of contemporary culture. This plan brings together local community efforts and practical tech tools, giving Xangani speakers a realistic and lasting way to keep their language alive.

CONCLUSION

This capstone project demonstrates that the Xangani language is central to the cultural identity and historical heritage of the Chiredzi community in Zimbabwe. Its ongoing decline represents a significant threat to the preservation of this unique cultural legacy. The study found that language loss in this context mirrors a global phenomenon, driven largely by the dominance of majority languages and a widening generational gap in linguistic proficiency. Despite these challenges, the research also uncovered a strong counter-narrative: community members show remarkable willingness to participate in revitalization initiatives. The findings suggest that effective preservation cannot rely solely on traditional methods. Instead, a strategic, multifaceted approach is essential. This study proposes a community-driven digital platform that combines a digital archive of oral histories with interactive learning tools. Such a platform offers a sustainable pathway for language transmission, leveraging widespread mobile phone access to transform a cultural threat into an opportunity for resurgence. Economically feasible and technologically accessible, this model empowers the community to actively safeguard their heritage.

Suggestions for Future Research

While this study lays the groundwork for understanding Xangani language preservation, several areas require further exploration. First, longitudinal studies should assess the effectiveness of digital platforms or similar technology-based solutions in improving youth language proficiency and encouraging community engagement over 12–24 months. Second, research could investigate how integrating Xangani language and traditions into cultural tourism or other economic ventures might support preservation efforts and generate income for the community. Finally, developing and evaluating a dedicated Xangani curriculum in local primary and secondary

schools would provide valuable insights into the feasibility, challenges, and acceptance of language education within national policy frameworks.

APPENDIX

Appendix A: Expert Interview Protocol

Purpose: To gather expert insights on the challenges, strategies, and potential solutions for ensuring the continued vitality of the Xangani language and its associated cultural heritage within Xangani oral traditions in Chiredzi, Zimbabwe.

Questions:

1. From your expertise, how critical is the connection between language and culture, specifically in the context of oral traditions?
2. What do you think are the most effective strategies for empowering communities like the Xangani to take ownership of their language preservation?
3. Do you think using digital archives, language learning platforms, and multimedia resources can be useful in preserving the language?
4. What are the most significant challenges and knowledge gaps that researchers face in language preservation efforts, particularly in the Zimbabwean context?
5. What are your recommendations for ensuring the long-term sustainability of Xangani language preservation efforts?
6. Do you have any final thoughts or advice for researchers working in this field?

Appendix B: Community Elder Interview Protocol

Purpose: To gather personal narratives, historical insights, and reflections on language use and oral traditions, documenting the knowledge held by community elders to ensure the Xangani language and culture continue for future generations.

Questions:

1. Can you describe how the language was spoken when you were younger compared to how it is spoken today?
2. Are there any specific cultural practices or ceremonies that you know that are closely tied to the Xangani language?
3. How do you feel about the way young people are using the Xangani language today?
4. How important is the Xangani language to the identity of our community? What does it mean to you personally?
5. What are some of the ways the community can work together to preserve the language?
6. Are there any economic or social factors that make it difficult for people to use the language?
7. What do you think is the best way to help the language thrive again?

Appendix C: Community Survey Questionnaire

Purpose: To understand the current state of the Xangani language and culture in Chiredzi and to help develop effective strategies for preserving the language and cultural heritage.

Sections:

Section 1: Demographic Information

- Age
- Gender

- Highest Level of Education
- Primary living area (Chiredzi Town or Rural Area)

Section 2: Language Use

- How often do you speak the Xangani language?
- In what settings do you usually speak Xangani? (e.g., At home with family, With friends and neighbors, During community events, At church or religious gatherings, At school/work, Other)
- How well do you understand the Xangani language?
- How well do you speak the Xangani language?
- Do you speak other languages regularly? If yes, which ones?
- Do you think younger generations are speaking Xangani as much as older generations?

Section 3: Cultural Knowledge and Oral Traditions

- How familiar are you with Xangani oral traditions (stories, songs, proverbs)?
- How often do you hear or participate in Xangani oral traditions?
- Do you believe it is important to preserve Xangani oral traditions?

Section 4: Language Preservation and Revitalization

- How important do you think it is to preserve the Xangani language?
- Are you willing to participate in language revitalization efforts?
- What types of language revitalization efforts do you think would be most effective? (e.g., Language classes for children and adults, Recording and documenting oral traditions, Using digital technology, Promoting language use in schools and community events, Creating Xangani language media, Other)
- Do you have access to the internet, and do you own a smart phone?
- What are the biggest challenges to the Xangani language survival?

- What ideas do you have for the language to survive?

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